

5.4 E-Mail Clients

E-Mail clients provide features that can take e-mailing beyond sending text messages or attaching pictures. Like with browsers, there are protocols that are used to send data via e-mail clients.

Today, with RSS feeds becoming more the rule than the exception in the case of news distribution, the role of an e-mail client will become more and more vital in arranging and sorting news e-mails. This is one area where an e-mail client scores heavily over Web-based e-mail: one can easily arrange folders, assign aliases, set up filters and spam blocks, and even block IPs. With Web-based e-mail, these features are limited by the service providers.

Most e-mail services support the POP3 and IMAP formats. They are two of the most popular protocols for sending e-mail. In POP3, the entire message is downloaded into the client from the server and then made available to be displayed. In IMAP, only the message stamp details, like the sender's mail ID, the date and time, and other such details are displayed, along with the initial portion of the message. Both protocols allow users to include binary attachments (MIME or other encoding) or HTML (normally found on Web pages) within their e-mails. They also convert URLs into clickable links, and this means graphic images, formatting, and even colour-coded text can be included in messages.

Mozilla Thunderbird 1.0.6

Just the way Firefox challenged IE in the browser space, Thunderbird has challenged Microsoft Outlook in the e-mail client space. Despite the fact that it's not as well featured as Outlook, it is just as powerful for e-mailing.

At a modest 5 MB download, this is a light package compared to other e-mail clients. It comes in a portable format as well, meaning you can carry your Thunderbird on a USB device. The interface is neat, with well-laid out buttons. The entire flow of the GUI and text is streamlined. Like all Mozilla prod-